

## Testimony of Tamara Gureghian (Philadelphia Regional Hearing)

My name is Tamara Gureghian. I have lived in Pennsylvania for 52 years, 42 of those years have been spent in Bucks County. The main things I'd like you to do when drawing district lines are as follows:

1) First, start with a clean slate. Do not worry about incumbents. Drawing district lines is challenging work. There are many competing interests: county lines, school districts, natural boundaries, community interests. Incumbent retention should not be one of them. If an incumbent is doing a good job, they will have a list of reasons why they should be elected in whatever district they find themselves in after a map is drawn from scratch. If they find themselves no longer living in a district in which they once served, then they can feel free to move into that district. Politicians should move to serve their people. District lines should not move to serve politicians. So wipe the slate clean and start fresh.

2) Second, establish your values. Drawing lines requires tough choices. There are many competing ways to draw maps. After wiping the slate clean, you must establish your top priorities in drawing a new map. My suggestion:

a. Establish as many competitive districts as possible. Yes, there are some areas of our Commonwealth that will always lean more blue or red, but there are other areas where the people are purple. That purpleness should be preserved and encouraged. Purple areas allow for more compromise and more give and take between the two major political parties. I live in a competitive district. I like it that way. Competitive districts encourage legislators to serve all the people. They also encourage all the people to vote. Every vote counts in a competitive district. You know that your individual vote can make the difference between a win and a loss. Competitive districts allow the will of the people to influence decision making. While you may not always get what you want in a competitive district, you feel represented. You feel like you have a chance at influencing a decision. Legislators are more responsive and communicative in competitive districts. They have an ear on the people to hear which way they are leaning on issues and they are able to respond accordingly. When the will of the people changes, we should see a shift in decision making. This shift is crucial in a healthy democracy. Simply put, competitiveness equals compromise which equals a healthy democracy. Therefore, I ask that you create a map with at least 7 competitive districts.

b. Respect minorities. Respect the Voting Rights Act. You will be able to see where minorities live. Ensure minorities have the ability to elect someone that understands and represents their values. This does not mean lump them all in one district, it means give them a fair shot at representation. Don't dilute their power and don't consolidate it. Let their presence have a measurable impact on elections so their voices are respected and heard.

c. Create districts with equal population.

d. Make the districts as compact and contiguous as possible.

These are the four main values I'd like you to consider when mapping. Sometimes these values will be difficult to balance. So long as you don't manipulate the values to create a partisan gerrymandered map, your map should be good for Pennsylvanians.

3) The third thing to keep in mind while mapping: be transparent. Drawing lines requires tough decisions. We understand that. We understand that no matter what lines you draw, some people will be unhappy. Nonetheless, more people will be content if you establish that your tough decisions were

based on ethical values. Public satisfaction is one of the many reasons why my second request, establish your values, is so important. Establishing your values will facilitate your ability to communicate your reasoning to the people. Thoughts that are outlined and revealed to the public will go a long way in restoring faith in our government. Case in point: I am very concerned about my personal district. I am part of one of the largest counties (Bucks) and one of the smaller communities (Warwick). I want Warwick to stay intact. We have issues that affect us as a whole. In particular, our water supply. If you split a small community like mine, we'd expect an explanation. Tell us why this line may not be good for this particular community, but it is good for the state as a whole. Let every Pennsylvanian feel like their community was considered. If a tough choice had to be made, so be it, but tell us why, explain, so we know it is not to keep one person or one party in power at the expense of a community. Be transparent with your values and reasoning.

4) Fourth, consider citizen drawn maps. The citizens of Pennsylvania have been working long and hard on trying to provide you with the best guidance possible in preserving our Commonwealth. Citizen made maps are available on Draw the Lines PA. You can see that the map by Nicholas Booth prides itself on ensuring that districts are very compact and competitive. He outlines his reasoning for splitting counties. Corey Cohen does the same with his map which also considers minority representation. The maps on Draw the Lines PA, and their explanations, can serve as models of how to be transparent with map drawing.

5) Next, I'll discuss specifics. I'm worried about my county. Bucks County borders Montgomery County. I know the people in Montgomery County have been split up 5 ways in the past. I don't want the committee to appease Montgomery County residents at the cost of Bucks County residents. I don't want the splits shifted our way. Bucks County is a very rare district in that it is naturally purple. Thus, it makes sense to keep Bucks County whole. You must carefully decide which communities you will add to Bucks County to get to the required population. If you chose to attach a more right or left leaning community, you will destroy the competitiveness of the district. This destruction would be bad for Bucks County and bad for the Commonwealth. Look for a moderate, equally purple area to add to Bucks. Perhaps Horsham township or Montgomery township.

6) As you move forward, I ask for the following:

- a. Place the information about your hearings and how to testify on the general assembly website, not a partisan one. Binding this information to a partisan website sends a message of impropriety to the people. Placing it on the general assembly's website will foster a feeling of fairness.
- b. Hold hearings in a place and at a time convenient to Pennsylvanians. Include zoom meetings to accommodate our disabled population and pandemic concerns. Include meetings held at night and close to public transportation.
- c. Hold hearings jointly with the Senate Committee.
- d. Continue to allow public feedback. Present maps to the public and allow and invite public comment and feedback. This task is daunting and we are all here and willing to help. We can let you know if a community or geographic boundary or economic tie was inadvertently overlooked.
- e. Allow sufficient time for feedback on maps to be given—specifically, at least a week.

7) Finally, I will end where I began. Start with a clean slate. If you do, you will send a much-needed message to the Commonwealth that the people of Pennsylvania come first. I strongly believe a good map will come from starting fresh and disregarding where incumbents live. Many map makers have shown this to be possible. Set as your goal competitive districts. Use that as a starting point. Modify it slightly only to satisfy respecting minorities, districts with equal population, and compact and contiguous districts. Be transparent with the process and with your values and let the people give input on the maps you create before they are finalized.

Through a transparent collaborative process, Pennsylvania will be a paradigm for redistricting. After years of gerrymandering, our map can showcase how redistricting can be done fairly, responsibly and responsively. You have the power to produce a map that will be the paradigm for fair districts. Imagine the influx of population when citizens of the United States are reminded over and over again that Pennsylvania is the state where the legislature listens to the people, where things get done, where districts are fair. Then, in ten years, you will redraw the lines, not losing a district, but adding.